CAMERA CLUB
OF CENTRAL NEW ENGLAND

Digital Technique

Monochrome Conversion Tools

This technique is to explore the multiple options for optimizing tone control when converting color images to black and white.

We will explore 3 methods which provide varying degree of speed and flexibility to explore and define your desired monochrome masterpiece

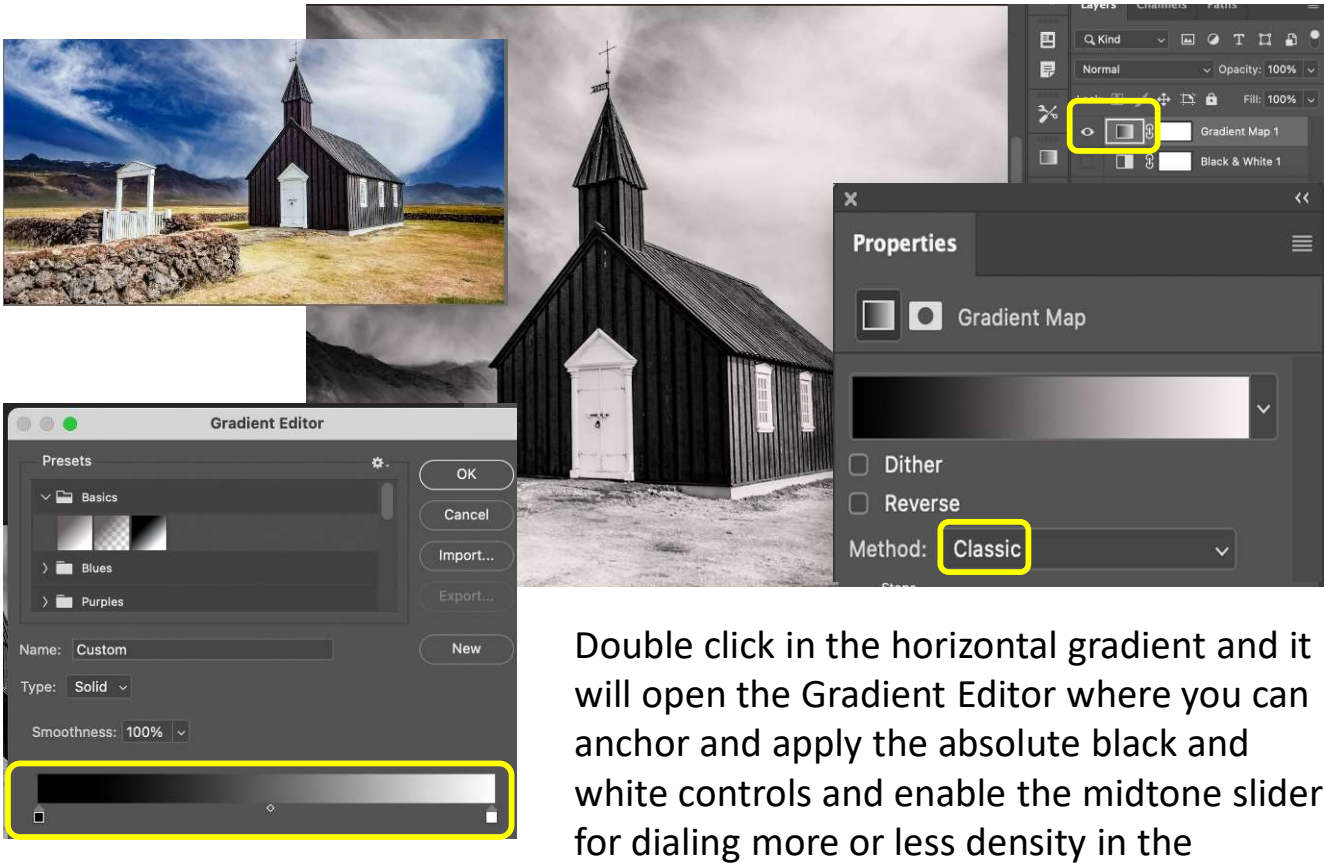
- Photoshop - Adjustment Layer – Gradient Map offering quick and easy conversion with variable tone controls particularly for mid tones
- Photoshop – Adjustment Layer – Black and White offering more in depth tonality controls based on individual color conversions
- Camera Raw – full range of edit controls offering ultimate dynamic manipulation

Here is a link to a You Tube video which illustrates this technique and other ideas that help, as well. Have a look and try these methods:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vR-yqShbV8o&t=51s

Photoshop - Adjustment Layer – Gradient Map

Start by opening your desired image in Photoshop. **Select Layers / New Adjustment Layer – Gradient Map.** Your image will now be in b&w. Double click on the gradient Icon in the layer which will open the Properties dialog and you want "classic" for the method

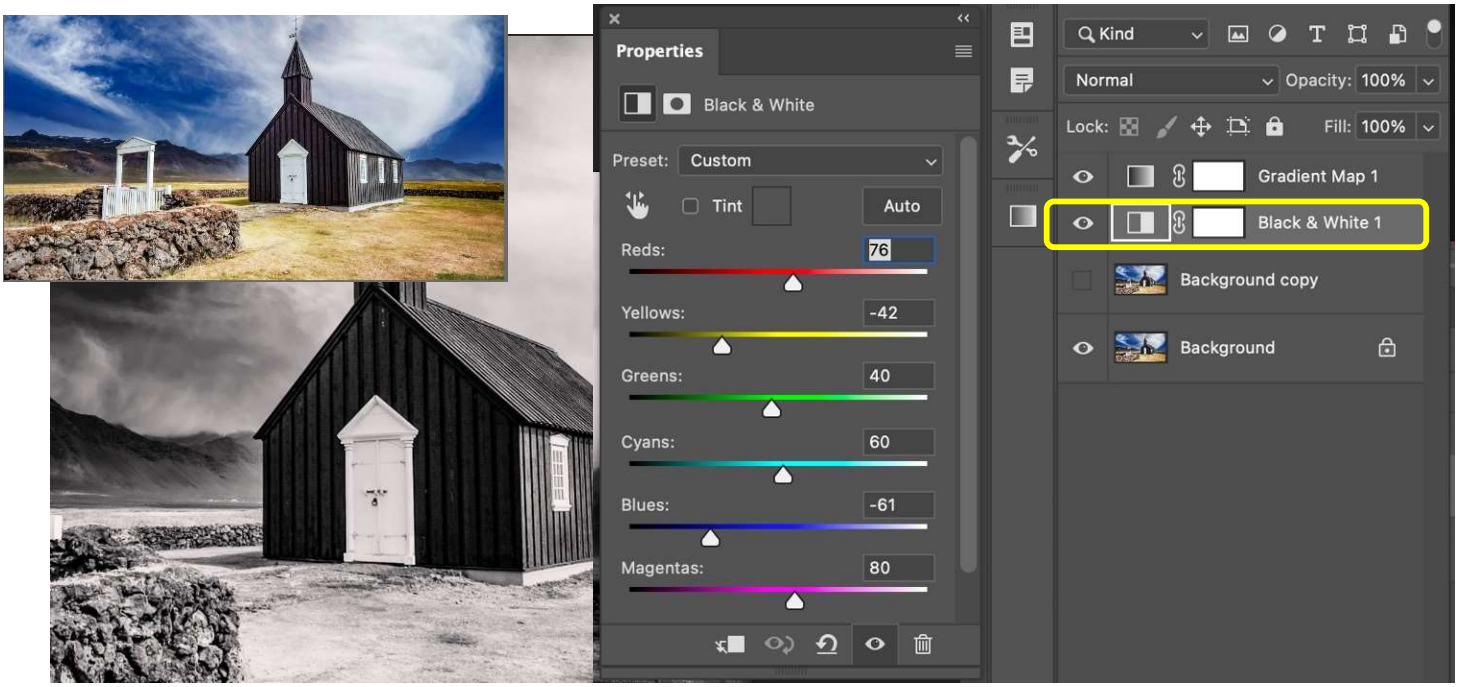


Double click in the horizontal gradient and it will open the Gradient Editor where you can anchor and apply the absolute black and white controls and enable the midtone slider for dialing more or less density in the midtones. Explore changing all three of these and watch the results on your image.

Explore changing any of three of these and watch the results on your image until your happy. Then save the image with a name that defines this as a B&W Gradient version so you don't overwrite the original color version. Save it as a .PSD if you want to revisit and explore more.

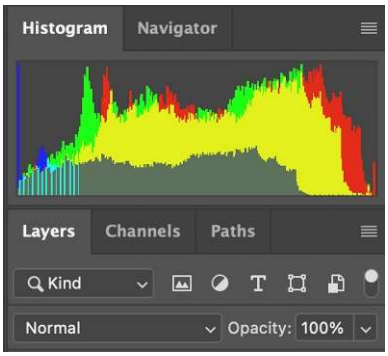
Photoshop - Adjustment Layer – Black and White

An alternative method would be opening your desired image in Photoshop. **Select Layers / New Adjustment Layer – Blak and White.** Your image will now be in b&w. Double click on the gradient Icon in the layer which will open the Properties dialog offering slider control to edit the b&w toneality of each individual color



An alternative method would be opening your desired image in Photoshop. **Select Layers / New Adjustment Layer – Black and White.**

Your image will now be in b&w. Double click on the gradient Icon in the layer which will open the Properties dialog offering slider control to edit the b&w toneality of each individual color. Evaluate the effect to the b&w tone for that color as you change any of them. You have a lot of control here. Notice the effect of changes to blue, in particular, as you can make very dramatic emphasis of the sky. Pay attention to your histogram in all of the methods as it is a good indicator of how where the dynamic changes in tonality are having the most effect

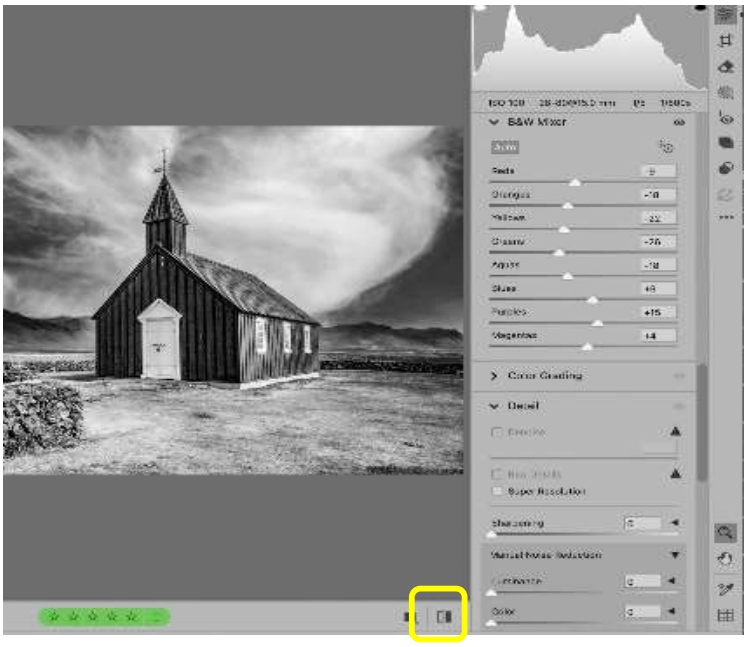


Camera Raw – Ultimate controls

The final method would be opening your desired image in Camera Raw. You can access this from Adobe Bridge, Lightroom or Photoshop.

If, Photoshop Select **Filters/ Camera Raw.** Your image will now be in color. Under Edit select B&W and the image will be rendered in b&w allowing considerable controls using all the options available in Camera Raw.

Leverage all the sliders to adjust b&w tonality and controls and in particular, explore Light, Effects, Color, Detail and most especially B&W Mixer.



Toggle to the default settings to show before and after results. When happy with the results, save with appropriate name and leverage .PSD to retain settings. Have fun!